

Resource: Study Notes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Study Notes (Tyndale)

ROM

Romans 1:1

- *a servant of Christ Jesus*: The word *servant* describes key Old Testament leaders of God's people, such as:
 - Moses ([2 Kings 18:12](#)),
 - Joshua ([Joshua 24:29](#)),
 - Elijah ([2 Kings 10:10](#)), and
 - David ([2 Samuel 7:8](#)).

This title emphasizes the apostle Paul's total submission to Christ as Lord.

- *set apart*: Paul may be saying that God set him apart for his mission before he was born. This idea is similar to the call of the prophet Jeremiah ([Jeremiah 1:5](#)). Paul may also be thinking about God's call during his conversion on the road to Damascus, when God chose him for a special task ([Acts 9:15-16](#); compare [Acts 13:2](#)). God called Paul to preach the good news about Jesus to Jews and especially to Gentiles (non-Jews).
- The good news, also called "the gospel," appears many times at the beginning of this letter ([Romans 1:1, 9, 15, 16](#)). Paul takes the word gospel from the Old Testament. There, the Hebrew word refers to news of victory. It describes the victory God wins for his people and the hope he brings to them ([Isaiah 40:9](#); [41:27](#); [60:6](#); [61:1](#); [Nahum 1:15](#); see [Joel 2:32](#)).

Romans 1:1-17

These verses include typical features of New Testament letter introductions:

- identifying the writer or speaker ([1:1-6](#)),
- identifying the audience ([1:7](#)),
- a section of giving thanks ([1:8-15](#)), and
- the theme of the letter ([1:16-17](#)).

Romans 1:3

- *According to the flesh*: Paul often uses the word *flesh* (Greek *sarx*) to speak about bodily life in this world (for example, [4:1](#); [8:3](#)).
- Paul mentions King David's family because God promised that a person descended from David would be the Messiah (God's chosen one) and would have an eternal kingdom ([2 Samuel 7:13-16](#); see [Isaiah 9:7](#); [Jeremiah 33:15](#)). Jesus was born into David's family line ([Matthew 1:6](#); [Luke 1:27, 32](#)). This shows that he met God's requirement to fulfill this promise.

Romans 1:3-4

In the Greek text, these verses have a parallel structure. Paul might be quoting an early Christian statement of belief or a song about Jesus Christ as God's Son. He likely does this to show that they shared the same beliefs, since he had not yet visited them.

Romans 1:4

was declared with power to be: Although Jesus has existed forever as the Son of God, his resurrection demonstrated him to be God's Son, revealing him in all his power and glory. ([1:3](#)).

Romans 1:5

- *received ... apostleship:* The apostle Paul might be referring to both himself and the other apostles, or he might be using "we" to only refer to himself.
- *we received grace and apostleship:* Paul always makes it evident that his unique authority is a gift from God (see also [15:15-16](#)).
- *to the obedience that comes from faith:* This summarizes Paul's goal in preaching to *Gentiles* (non-Jews). It frames the book of Romans, as he repeats the idea in different words at the end of the letter ([16:26](#)). Paul wanted Gentiles to trust in Jesus Christ. He emphasized that trusting in Jesus Christ as the Lord means committing to obey him. Faith and obeying are not the same, but one does not happen without the other.

Romans 1:7

be saints: This essentially means to be set apart for God. This expression appears throughout the Old Testament to describe Israel, God's people whom he chose (compare [Exodus 19:6](#)). God called Israel from among all other nations to belong to him. Paul calls the Gentile (non-Jewish) Christians "saints." Paul makes it plain that Gentiles who trust in Christ are now fully included among God's people.

Romans 1:9

with my spirit: This might mean God's Holy Spirit influences Paul's inner self. The word *spirit* also refers to the deepest part of a person.

Romans 1:11

some spiritual gift: Paul probably means the spiritual benefit he hopes his ministry will bring to the Roman Christians.

Romans 1:13

- *brothers:* The Greek word *adelphoi* describes people who are in a family relationship. Paul and other New Testament writers use this word to show that Christians belong to one family because they are united in Christ. The word refers to both male and female Christians.
- *but have been prevented from visiting until now:* Paul wrote this letter while in Corinth near the end of his third missionary journey (see [Acts 20:2-4](#); compare [Romans 16:21-23](#)). Paul had been busy planting and supporting churches in the eastern Mediterranean. Before visiting the Roman Christians, he needed to return to Jerusalem to deliver money collected from the Gentile (non-Jewish) churches for the poor Jewish Christians ([15:23-29](#)).

Romans 1:14

to Greeks and non-Greeks: The Greeks were proud of being educated and cultured. They often thought people from other cultures were inferior. They mocked the way foreigners spoke Greek, saying it sounded like "bar bar," a meaningless sound. From this mockery comes the word *barbarian* (a person seen as uncivilized). Paul refers to this cultural divide to show that he wanted to preach the good news about Jesus to every kind of person.

Romans 1:16

The apostle Paul often emphasizes that the *gospel* (the good news about Jesus) is for *everyone*. He also insists that God first chose the Jews to be his people. God made promises to them and gave them a unique role in his continuing plan ([3:1-8](#); [9:1-5](#)). They have a special responsibility to respond to the gospel. They will experience God's judgment first if they reject the gospel ([2:9-10](#)).

Romans 1:17

- *the righteousness of God*: This important phrase appears eight times in Romans (see also [3:5](#), [21](#), [22](#), [25](#), [26](#); [10:3](#); the only other occurrence in Paul's writings is [2 Corinthians 5:21](#)). In the Old Testament, God's righteousness refers to who God is (holy and faithful) and to what God does when he rescues his people and makes things right (see especially [Isaiah 46:13](#); [51:5-8](#)). Paul uses the second meaning in this verse. The gospel (the good news about Jesus) has the power to save because it fulfills God's promise to defend his people.
- *"The righteous will live by faith"*: The prophet Habakkuk struggled to understand how God could use nations that worshiped false gods to judge his own people, Israel. God reminded Habakkuk that his true people were the righteous, who needed to live by faith ([Habakkuk 2:4](#)). In [Romans 1-4](#), Paul often insists that only by faith can humans become right with God.

Romans 1:18

The wrath of God: God's wrath (or anger) is not a sudden emotional reaction. It is the holy God's necessary response to human sin. Because God is just and good, God must respond to what destroys life and faithfulness.

The Old Testament often describes God's wrath in specific historical events, such as Israel's rebellion or injustice among the people ([Exodus 32:10-12](#); [Numbers 11:1](#); [Jeremiah 21:3-7](#)). It also looks ahead to a future time when God will judge human sin in a final and decisive way.

Paul usually speaks of God's wrath as something that will happen at the end of history ([Romans 2:5, 8](#); [5:9](#); [Colossians 3:6](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:10](#)). However, when Paul uses the present tense and says that God's wrath "is revealed," he points to God's actions in history as well. These passages show that God has already responded to sin throughout human history, not only at the end of time.

Romans 1:18-3:20

Paul waits to explain righteousness through faith (see [3:21](#)) until he first teaches about the sinfulness of all people. Both non-Jews and Jews are equally under the power of sin ([1:18-32](#); [2:1-3:8](#)). Because of this, both groups are in the same situation before God. No one can gain God's favor by their own actions or obedience ([3:9-20](#)). All people need God's saving action, not their own efforts.

Romans 1:21

In Scripture, to know God usually means to have a close and saving relationship with him (see [2 Corinthians 5:16](#); [Galatians 4:9](#); [Philippians 3:8, 10](#)). Here, however, *they knew God* means that people knew about God. All people have some understanding of God through creation, but they do not do what is right based on that knowledge. Instead of learning more about God, they worship gods they create themselves.

Romans 1:24

When people replaced the living God with idols (false gods), God abandoned them. Paul emphasizes this point twice more in this paragraph ([1:26, 28](#)). The phrase *gave them over* suggests that God actively allows people to experience the consequences of their sin.

Romans 1:26

Even their women exchanged natural relations for unnatural ones: In this context, *the natural way* refers to the nature of the world as God made it.

As in the Old Testament, Paul refers to same-sex sexual behavior as one example of how people have turned away from honoring the true God (see [Genesis 19:1–28](#); [Leviticus 18:22](#); [Leviticus 20:13](#); [Deuteronomy 23:17–18](#)).

God created human beings as male and female, and engaging in same-sex sexual activity is a violation of God's creative intention.

Romans 1:27

received in themselves the due penalty for their error: When people turn away from the Creator's purposes, God judges their actions. This judgment can happen in many ways, but the final result is spiritual death (see [1:32](#)).

Romans 1:28

they did not see fit to acknowledge: Sin affects what people do and how they think. One serious result of turning away from God is an unsound mind. People can no longer think in the way God intended.

Romans 1:29–31

This list of sins follows a popular Hellenistic literary form called a *vice list* (a list that names sinful behaviors). The list does not include every sin, but it shows the many ways evil can appear.

Romans 1:32

To encourage others to sin is worse than sinning oneself ([James 3:1](#); compare *Testament of Asher* 6:2: "The two-faced receive double punishment because they practice evil and approve of others who do the same; they imitate the spirits of error and join in the fight against humanity").

Romans 2:1–5

- *You* is singular in the Greek text. Here, *you* refers to a hypothetical Jew who feels superior to Gentiles and believes that he is not in danger of judgment. Paul uses a popular Hellenistic writing style called a *diatribe* (a teaching method that presents a debate with an imagined opponent). In this style, the writer argues against a made-up person in order to persuade the audience.
- *the same things:* Paul's means that Jews, like Gentiles, turn away from God's revelation and choose to follow their own path.

Romans 2:4

not realizing that God's kindness leads you to repentance?: Jewish writings describe a common attitude of false security about judgment (for example, *Wisdom of Solomon* 12–15; compare [Jeremiah 7:1–5](#); [Amos 5:18–27](#)). Paul uses this idea when he asks his question. Many Jews believed that because they were God's people, they did not need to fear judgment. They thought their sins would not be punished in the same way as the sins of Gentiles. Paul makes clear that God's grace was meant to turn Jews away from sin, not to approve of a sinful way of life.

Romans 2:6–11

Paul uses a chiasm (a pattern shaped like an "X," where ideas are repeated in reverse order) to make his point:

- A God judges everyone the same ([2:6](#))
 - B Life is the reward for doing good ([2:7](#))
 - C Wrath is the penalty for evil ([2:8](#))
 - C' Wrath for doing evil ([2:9](#))
 - B' Life for doing good ([2:10](#))
- A' God shows no favoritism ([2:11](#))

Romans 2:7

To those ... doing good ... He will give eternal life: Paul explains elsewhere that no one can receive eternal life except as God's gift through faith ([3:20](#), [28](#); [4:1-8](#)). Here, Paul may be speaking about Christians whose good actions come from faith and will be considered in God's judgment. Or he may be pointing to God's perfect standard of holiness, which shows that only complete perfection could bring acceptance before God. As Paul's argument continues, he shows that no one is able to meet this standard.

Romans 2:8

self-seeking: This phrase translates a rare Greek word, *eritheia*, which means selfish ambition or strife. The Greek philosopher Aristotle used this word to criticize politicians of his time. He said they pursued public office for personal gain instead of wanting to serve the people (Aristotle, *Politics* 5.3; see also [2 Corinthians 12:20](#); [Galatians 5:20](#); [Philippians 1:17](#); [2:3](#); [James 3:14](#), [16](#)).

Romans 2:12

- *Perish:* This common New Testament word describes the final outcome of the wicked after judgment (see also [9:22](#); [14:15](#); [1 Corinthians 1:18](#); [15:18](#); [2 Corinthians 2:15](#); [4:3](#); [Philippians 1:28](#); [3:19](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:10](#); [1 Timothy 6:9](#)). It refers to complete ruin and loss under God's judgment.
- *all ... under the law:* The Jews received the law of Moses, while the Gentiles (non-Jewish people) never had God's written law. In the New Testament period, Jews saw having the law as a mark of God's favor towards them and even as a guarantee of salvation.

Romans 2:13

the doers of the law who will be declared righteous: Regarding the promise of righteousness through obedience, see [2:7](#) and [James 1:22](#).

Romans 2:14-15

Gentiles, who do not have the law, do by nature what the law requires: This fits with the idea that the law is written on their hearts ([2:15](#)), which points to the promise of the new covenant ([Jeremiah 31:31-34](#)).

Or Paul may be speaking about non-Christian Gentiles. These Gentiles know God's basic moral law through their conscience. In this case, Paul shows that all people can be held responsible for basic moral standards, even without God's written law.

Romans 2:16

secrets (literally the hidden things): Scripture often emphasizes that God will judge people based on their thoughts and intentions (see [1 Samuel 16:7](#); [Psalm 139:1-2](#); [Jeremiah 17:10](#)).

Romans 2:17-20

The pride of the Jews reflects Old Testament and Jewish teachings about the privileges and responsibilities God gave to Israel. God gave his law to Israel, formed a special relationship with them, and gave them the task of being a spiritual light to the Gentiles (see [Isaiah 42:6-7](#)). Jews were not wrong to enjoy these blessings; their error was in failing to live up to their privileged position.

Romans 2:21-22

Paul again uses the diatribe style (a teaching method that argues with an imagined opponent) to show the inconsistency in Jewish claims (see study note on 2:1-5).

Romans 2:22

do you rob temples?: Old Testament law prohibited Jews from having anything to do with pagan idols (see [Deuteronomy 7:26](#)). Pagans were those who worshiped false gods, and idols were hand-made representations of these false gods. But first-century AD Jews did not always follow this law. Sometimes they stole idols and used or sold the valuable metals from which the pagans made the idols.

Romans 2:24

Paul quotes [Isaiah 52:5](#), where God's name is blasphemed because Israel is oppressed by pagan nations. Here, Paul uses that passage to demonstrate the failure of the Jews to live up to their responsibilities.

Romans 2:25

God established the Jewish ceremony of circumcision as a sign of his covenant (special agreement) with Abraham. God required that every male Israelite child be circumcised ([Genesis 17:9-13](#); see [Romans 4:11](#)). Circumcision represents God's covenant with his people, Israel.

The ceremony became more important during the intertestamental period (the time between the Old and New Testaments). During this time, the pagan king Antiochus IV Epiphanes tried to destroy the

Jewish faith. He did this by forbidding circumcision and other Jewish practices.

The Jews resisted him in the Maccabean Revolt (166-160 BC). After they restored worship of the Lord in Israel, the Jews viewed circumcision as a valued sign of loyalty to God while living among pagan peoples.

Romans 2:26

will not his uncircumcision be regarded as circumcision?: Paul might be referring to Gentile Christians who are God's people because they follow God's law. Alternatively, he could be speaking in an imaginary way about what would happen if a non-Jew perfectly obeyed God's law.

Romans 2:29

the written code: This refers to God's law written on tablets of stone (see [2 Corinthians 3:3](#)). Now the Holy Spirit writes God's law on people's hearts, meaning that God places his law within them and changes how they think and live ([Jeremiah 31:33-34](#)). This contrast shows the difference between obeying rules only on the outside and obeying God because he has changed a person's inner life.

Romans 3:1

What, then, is the advantage of being a Jew?: Paul advances his argument by asking questions. After preaching the gospel (the good news about Jesus) for over twenty years, he knew what questions people would ask when they heard a specific teaching. His focus on the equality of Jews and non-Jews (Gentiles) before God (chapter [2](#)) naturally invited people to ask if he was removing all Jewish privileges. The question-and-answer style follows the pattern of the diatribe style. In this method, a speaker asks questions and then answers them to correct or guide the listener (see study note on 2:1-5).

Romans 3:2

- The Jews had the advantage of receiving words of God.
- *First of all*: Paul does not add a second or third point to his list. He might have forgotten to continue, or *first of all* might mean "most importantly." However, [9:4-5](#) suggests what a list of Jewish privileges might include.
- By using the phrase *very words* (Greek *logia*, meaning "oracles" or "messages"), Paul emphasizes God's personal communication with his people (see [Deuteronomy 33:9](#); [Psalm 105:19](#)). Through this, God gives them special privileges and responsibilities.

Romans 3:4

- *Certainly not!*: The Greek phrase *mē genoito* is a strong way to say "no." Paul often uses this style of argument in other parts of Romans (see [3:6](#), [31](#); [6:2](#), [15](#); [7:7](#), [13](#); [9:14](#); [11:1](#), [11](#)).
- *As it is written*: Paul quotes [Psalm 51:4](#), where King David admitted his sin of committing adultery with Bathsheba (see [2 Samuel 11:1-27](#)). God punished David, and David admitted that God was right to judge him. David accepted that God's judgment was completely just. God remains faithful to everything he has said in the past. This includes his whole revelation. God's words warn people about punishment for sin, but they also promise blessing for obedience.

Romans 3:5-7

how could God judge the world?: Abraham asked a similar question: "Will not the Judge of all the earth do what is right?" ([Genesis 18:25](#)). God punishes all sin and maintains absolute righteousness while doing so. Even when God makes use of human sin

for his own ends, that sin still deserves to be, and will be, punished (see [Romans 9:10-24](#)).

Romans 3:8

some slanderously claim that we say: Paul is referring to misrepresentations about his teaching on justification by faith. If a person is made right with God by faith alone, through God's grace and apart from works, it could seem as if the gospel allows Christians to sin because God forgives their sin when they confess it (see [6:1](#)). One of Paul's purposes is to help the Roman Christians understand that such misunderstandings are without basis.

Romans 3:9

- *Not at all*: Paul's strong response does not contradict his earlier statement in [3:1-2](#) that Jews have an advantage. However, this advantage has not benefited them because they did not obey God's commands and encountered God's punishment. Jews, like Gentiles (here, *Greeks*), have sinned against the revelation of God and stand condemned.
- *under sin*: Being "under" something means it controls a person. The main problem for humans is not only that they have sin, but they are slaves of sin. The solution to this problem is the freedom that Christ Jesus provides. He frees people from both the penalty and the power of sin.

Romans 3:10-12

This quotation from [Psalms 14:1-3](#); [53:1-3](#) directly supports the argument that all people are under the power of sin.

Romans 3:10–18

The six quotations in these verses come from different parts of the Old Testament. All of them speak about human sinfulness.

Paul follows a teaching practice used by Jewish teachers. They gathered several Old Testament passages that shared the same theme and placed them together. This method is sometimes called *pearl-stringing* (linking texts one after another to make a single point).

Romans 3:13–14

Paul here speaks about sins of speech. In each of the four lines, he mentions a different part of the body used for speaking.

Romans 3:15–17

This quotation from [Isaiah 59:7–8](#) discusses sins committed against others.

Romans 3:18

There is no: This concluding quotation from [Psalm 36:1](#) effectively summarizes the entire series ([Romans 3:10–18](#)). It uses the same Greek words, *ouk estin*, that begin the first quotation. In [Romans 3:10](#), the phrase is translated “There is no one.”

Romans 3:19

- Paul refers to the entire Old Testament as *the law* (see also [1 Corinthians 9:8](#), [9: 14:21](#), [34](#); [Galatians 4:21](#)).
- The Jews, who received the Scriptures, were those to whom God gave the law (literally, *those in the law*).
- How can Paul conclude that *the whole world [is] held accountable to God* based on Old Testament evidence that Jews are sinful? He uses a common Jewish technique of argument, reasoning from the greater idea to the lesser. The law shows that the Jews, the people God chose, are accountable. So, the non-Jews (Gentiles), who did not receive God's instruction, are even more accountable.

Romans 3:20

by works of the law: This means obeying the rules given by Moses, the prophet and leader of Israel. While this phrase refers to Jews, the principle extends to all people. If Jews cannot be put in right relationship with God by obeying the law God gave them, certainly other people cannot establish such a relationship through good deeds.

Romans 3:21–22

- After a long discussion about the power of sin ([1:18–3:20](#)), Paul returns to the main idea in [1:17](#), which is how to be in a right relationship with God (literally *the righteousness of God*). In [1:17](#), “the righteousness of God” is the way that God puts people in right relationship with himself.
- *apart from the law*: The old covenant looked ahead to God’s righteousness being revealed in his Son, Jesus Christ. Through Christ, God fulfilled the law for us. Because of what God has accomplished for us in Christ by completely fulfilling the requirements of the law, we are now able to come to him by faith, apart from the covenant structure set up by the law of Moses (see [Hebrews 8:13](#)).

Romans 3:21–4:25

Paul returns to the central theme of God’s righteousness. This righteousness is revealed in Jesus Christ and is available to anyone who believes.

Paul states this teaching most clearly in [3:21–26](#). Paul explains it further in [3:27–31](#). He then shows how it works by using the experience of Abraham in chapter [4](#).

Romans 3:24

- *by His grace*: God places us in a right relationship with him, not because he must, but because God chooses to give us his favor through Christ Jesus. Because we are helpless slaves of sin ([3:9](#)), our righteous status before God can never be earned (see [4:4–5](#)).
- *through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus*: In Paul’s day, *redemption* referred to the price paid to free a slave. God paid our redemption price with the blood of his own Son to rescue us from our slavery to sin (see [3:9](#)). This language was used in the Old Testament to refer to the exodus from Egypt, the first redemption of God’s people from slavery (see [2 Samuel 7:23](#)). God promised that he would again redeem his people ([Hosea 13:14](#); [Micah 4:10](#)).

Romans 3:25

- *As an atoning sacrifice* (Greek *hilastērion*): This Greek word appears in the Greek Old Testament. It refers to the atonement cover, the lid placed on the ark of the covenant inside the most sacred room of the tabernacle. This cover played a central role in the Day of Atonement ceremony ([Leviticus 16](#)). Over time, the word came to represent the atonement ritual itself. Paul uses this word to describe Jesus Christ. God provided Jesus as the final sacrifice for sin. Through Jesus, God deals fully with human sin. Jesus bears God's righteous anger against sin himself (see [Romans 1:18](#)).
- *the sins committed beforehand*: Paul refers to faithful people in the Old Testament period whose sins were not punished as strict justice would require. The letter to the Hebrews explains that animal sacrifices could not truly remove sin ([Hebrews 10:4](#)). So how could God forgive people before Christ? Paul explains that Jesus's sacrifice works both backward and forward in time. Through Christ, God fully satisfied his righteous judgment against human sin for all people.

Romans 3:29-30

Paul builds his argument on the Jewish belief that there is only one God. From this belief, he shows that God offers forgiveness to all people.

If there is only one God, then he is the God of both Jews and Gentiles. Because of this, all people must be able to come to God in the same way. They come to him through faith.

Romans 3:31

Instead, we uphold the law: Paul knows that some people will object to his teaching about faith apart

from the law. It may sound as if he is setting aside the law's demands.

However, faith does not cancel the law. Faith makes it possible for people to live as the law requires. God gives the Holy Spirit to those who have faith, and the Spirit enables them to do what is right.

Romans 4:1

Jews in Paul's time honored Abraham as the founder of Israel. Some Jewish writings even claim that Abraham never sinned (*Prayer of Manasseh* 8; *Jubilees* 23:10). Other writings stress his obedience and connect his relationship with God to keeping the law of Moses (*1 Maccabees* 2:52; *Sirach* 44:19-20).

Paul argues differently. He shows that Abraham's faith, not his obedience to the law, is what put him in a right relationship with God. Because Abraham is the founder of God's people, his example shows that being made right with God by faith stands at the center of God's plan.

Romans 4:3

Paul quotes [Genesis 15:6](#). In response to God's promise that his descendants would be as numerous as the stars in the sky, Abraham trusted God. It was faith that established Abraham's relationship with God.

This relationship did not come from works, circumcision, the law, or the number of his descendants ([Romans 4:3-21](#)).

Romans 4:4-5

The logic of these verses is as follows:

1. When people work, their pay is what they earn, not a gift.
2. The idea not stated is that God never owes his creatures anything. They owe him everything. So, anything he gives is a gift (see also [9:14-16](#)).
3. The conclusion is that God does not place people in a right relationship with him because of their works.

Romans 4:7-8

This quotation from [Psalm 32:1-2](#) follows the Jewish tradition of supporting a reference to the law with one from the prophets or writings. Paul also uses a Jewish way of interpreting Scripture. This method links different quotations by repeating a key word. Here, *count* translates the same Greek word as "credited" in [Romans 4:3](#).

Romans 4:10

God accepted Abraham before circumcision. Paul's point is simple: God "credited" Abraham as righteous in [Genesis 15:6](#) before his circumcision, which happened later ([Genesis 17](#)). This shows that God's acceptance and blessing are free gifts, not earned by works of the law.

Romans 4:11-12

When God introduced circumcision, he called it "a sign of the covenant" between himself and Abraham ([Genesis 17:11](#)). The covenant existed before Abraham became circumcised ([Genesis 12:1-3](#); [15:1-21](#); [17:1-8](#)). This shows that it was on the basis of faith, not circumcision. Therefore, Abraham is the spiritual father of all people, whether circumcised (Jews) or uncircumcised (Gentiles), "who are of the faith of Abraham" ([Romans 4:13-25](#)).

Romans 4:13

of the world: God told Abraham that he would be the father of many nations ([4:17](#); [Genesis 12:2](#); [13:16](#); [15:5](#); [17:4-6](#), [16-20](#); [22:17](#)). God also said Abraham would bring blessings to all people ([Genesis 12:3](#); [18:18](#); [22:18](#); compare [Isaiah 55:3-5](#)).

Romans 4:14

faith is useless (literally *faith has become empty*): If works of the law could replace faith, then faith would lose its importance. Trusting in God means recognizing our need and relying completely on God's mercy, which leads to a life of obedience.

Romans 4:15

where there is no law, neither is there transgression: Paul always uses the word *transgression* to mean not obeying a plain commandment of God (see also [2:23](#); [5:14](#); [Galatians 3:19](#); [1 Timothy 2:14](#)). So, transgression can only exist where the law exists. This is why violating the law always brings punishment. The law that God gave to the Israelites had detailed requirements. This made the people more accountable for sin than before their law existed. When they inevitably violated this law, God punished them more severely.

Romans 4:16

not only to those who are of the law: The Jews were *of the law* in that their covenant with God included the law of Moses and they were to live according to it.

Romans 4:24

raised ... from the dead: Abraham experienced the life-giving power of God in the birth of his son Isaac. Christians witness it in the resurrection of Jesus. Throughout history, salvation has been available only through faith in God, who makes and keeps his promises.

Romans 5:1

- *We have peace*: In many manuscripts, the Greek verb states a fact. This form means “we have peace” and presents peace as something believers already possess. Other manuscripts use a different verb form that expresses an appeal or encouragement. In that case, the meaning would be “let us have peace.”
- Peace with God does not mean only a feeling of calm. It describes a real situation. When people believe in Jesus Christ, hostility between God and sinful human beings comes to an end. This peace also includes the blessing and salvation God promised his people in the future (see [Isaiah 9:6-7](#); [52:7](#); [Ezekiel 34:25](#); [Nahum 1:15](#)).

Romans 5:1-8:39

Paul now moves from the good news about how people begin a relationship with God to the security of that relationship. Christians have a strong and lasting promise. This promise rests on God’s work in Jesus Christ, God’s love for them, and the power of the Holy Spirit.

This promise shapes the teaching in these chapters ([5:1-11](#); [8:18-39](#)). Paul explains it by showing that believers have been moved from the realm of Adam to the realm of Christ ([5:12-21](#)). Because of this change, no power can break this relationship. Sin (chapter [6](#)), the law (chapter [7](#)), or death ([8:1-13](#)) cannot separate believers from God’s love ([8:39](#)).

Romans 5:2

- *Grace*: God’s grace (Greek *charis*) is so central that Paul uses this word to describe our whole life as believers. Grace does not only begin the Christian life. Believers continue to depend on God’s grace every day.
- *in which we stand*: This indicates that we need God’s grace throughout the Christian life, not just at the beginning.
- Sharing God’s glory describes the hope believers have for the future. Paul introduces this hope here and explains it more fully later ([8:18-30](#)). When Paul speaks about glory (Greek *doxa*), he bases his meaning on the Hebrew word *kabod* (which means “weight, honor, powerful presence”). This word describes God’s majesty and overwhelming presence. The prophets looked forward to a future time when God’s glory would return and live among his people (see, for example, [Isaiah 60:1-2](#)).

Romans 5:3-4

See also [James 1:2-4](#); [1 Peter 1:6-7](#). The similarities in these passages indicate early Christian teaching common to all three of these writers.

Romans 5:5

- *hope does not disappoint* (literally *does not put to shame*): In the Old Testament, shame sometimes means that God has judged someone as guilty (for example, [Isaiah 28:16](#), quoted in [Romans 9:33](#)).
- *has poured out His love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit*: See [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [Acts 2:17-21](#).

Romans 5:6

at just the right time: This could mean God sent Christ at a specific historical moment. It could also mean our totally vulnerable spiritual condition was the perfect time for God to demonstrate his love by sending his Son on our behalf.

Romans 5:9

- The blood of Christ refers to the sacrificial death of Jesus ([3:25](#)). In the Scriptures, *blood* often means a violent death, especially when that death "makes atonement" for sins ([Leviticus 17:11](#)).
- *how much more shall we be saved from wrath through Him!:* Paul often describes salvation as the final rescue of Christians from God's wrath and life's troubles (see [Romans 13:11](#)).

Romans 5:10

saved through His life: Christians already share in the new life that Christ provided through his resurrection ([6:11](#)). Because believers are joined to Christ, God will spare them from his final judgment on the last day (see also [Colossians 3:4](#)).

Romans 5:12

- Adam is both the name of the first man and a Hebrew word that means "human." Paul emphasizes Adam's connection with the human race.
- *sin entered the world:* The importance Paul gives to this act, and the way he compares Adam's sin with Christ's obedience on the cross, shows that Paul understood Adam and the sin in the garden of Eden as real events in history.
- *all sinned:* Death affects everyone because sin affects everyone. It is uncertain when or how all sinned. But Paul later attributes the condemnation of all people to the sin of Adam, their representative ([5:18](#)).
- Jewish tradition is not united on how Adam's sin relates to the sin and death of all human beings. Different Jewish texts explain this relationship in different ways. Some texts teach a strong connection between Adam and all other people. These writings say that Adam's sin brought death to the whole human family. One example says, "when Adam sinned, a death was decreed for those yet to be born" (2 *Baruch* 23:4). Other texts place responsibility on each individual person. These writings say that people die because of their own sin, not because of Adam's sin. One text states, "Adam is not the cause, except for himself; each of us has become our own Adam" (2 *Baruch* 54:19).

Romans 5:13-14

Paul continues his explanation of "all sinned" ([5:12](#)) by stating that people who died between the times of Adam and Moses were not subject to specific commandments from God. Therefore, their condemnation was not only because of their own

sin. It was because of their union with Adam, who sinned by violating a clear commandment of God.

Romans 5:15

Paul uses the word *many* to contrast with *one*. *Many* does not always mean *all*, but it can include everyone if the context suggests it. In this passage, the many who suffer death because of Adam clearly includes everyone (see [5:12](#)). However, Paul explains elsewhere that the many who receive the gift of forgiveness through Jesus Christ does not include everyone (see [11:1-5](#)).

Romans 5:17

Both Adam and Jesus Christ performed a single act whose effects reach all the people they represent. Adam represents all people. To be represented by Christ, people must receive the gift of righteousness.

Romans 5:18

- Christ's one act of righteousness refers to his death on the cross, a righteous act because Christ chose to die in obedience to the Father's will (see [John 10:18](#)).
- *life for all men*: Paul is not teaching that all people will experience the new life that Christ won through his death on the cross. New life is available to everyone through Christ, but not everyone receives it.

Romans 5:20

Many Jews believed that God's law, given to Israel, reversed or reduced the harmful effects of Adam's sin. Paul says instead that God's law caused sin to increase and helped people see their sin more clearly.

Romans 6:1

What then: Because Paul has just proclaimed that God multiplies grace where sin increases ([5:20](#)), he knows that people will wonder whether this means that sin does not matter in the Christian life.

Romans 6:2

we who died to sin: Paul explains in [6:3-10](#) our new relationship to sin is possible because we are closely connected to the death of Jesus. Just as dying means entrance into an entirely new state of being, our relationship with sin is now different because of Christ's death.

To be dead to sin does not mean that believers no longer feel temptation or desire to sin. Believers are still involved in a struggle against sin ([6:12-14](#)). However, Christians no longer have to live as helpless slaves to sin. Because of Christ's death, they are able to choose not to sin ([6:6](#), [14](#), [16-22](#)).

Romans 6:3

Baptism is the ceremony that initiates a person into the Christian faith (see [Acts 2:38](#), [41](#)). It sometimes represents the whole conversion experience. Paul describes baptism as the way Christians unite to Christ in his death and resurrection (see also [Romans 6:4](#)). However, baptism has no value apart from faith.

Romans 6:4

We were therefore buried with Christ: The Christian's power over sin and ability to lead a new life come from union with Christ's death, burial, and resurrection (see [6:5](#), [8](#)). From God's perspective, because Jesus died to sin, Christians have as well (see [6:10](#)). The resurrection of Jesus means we also start a new life, and in the future, our bodies will also be raised.

Romans 6:6

our old self: Our "old self" is not only a part of us. It represents who we were in spiritual union with Adam. All humans were born "in Adam." As those who inherit the effects of sin and death he brought

into the world, humans became slaves to sin's power ([5:12](#)).

Now, however, we are in Christ. We have shared in his death on the cross (see also [Galatians 2:20](#)). When he died on the cross, the old self of Christians also died to the power of sin that once controlled them.

Romans 6:8

we will also live with him: This means we will experience a resurrection of our bodies with Christ (see [6:5](#)). Christians are already spiritually resurrected with Christ ([Ephesians 2:5-6](#); [Colossians 2:13](#)). We will also experience a physical resurrection when he returns in glory ([2 Corinthians 4:14](#); [Philippians 3:21](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:17](#); [2 Timothy 2:11](#)).

Romans 6:10

He died to sin once for all: Because Christians spiritually died with Jesus, we have also died to sin ([6:4-5](#); [6:2](#)). Jesus was never under sin's power like we were, because he did not inherit the effects of sin from Adam and never committed sin ([2 Corinthians 5:21](#); [Hebrews 4:15](#)). However, when he became human, he entered a world where sin has power. In this human life, he was truly able to be tempted by sin.

Romans 6:14

- *You are not under law:* With the coming of Christ, the period ruled by the law of Moses came to an end (see [Galatians 3:19-25](#)).
- *under grace:* God has always acted toward his people with grace. However, grace now rules the new era in which Christians live in Christ. Compare [John 1:17](#).

Romans 6:15

we are not under law: The law of Moses ruled the period of the old covenant. Christians now live under the rule of Christ himself.

Romans 6:16

righteousness (Greek *dikaioσunē*): In the first part of Romans, Paul uses this Greek word in a legal sense. It refers either to God's action of placing people in a right relationship with himself or to the right standing believers receive because of Christ's work (see, for example, [1:17](#); [3:21-22](#); [4:3](#), [5](#)).

Here, Paul uses the same word in the way it is often used in the Old Testament. It means the right kind of behavior that God expects from his people.

Romans 6:19

Paul uses the Greek word *sarx* (human nature, or *flesh*) to describe human weakness and the tendency to sin. Paul uses the illustration of slavery to show the relationship of the human nature to sin.

Romans 6:20

free from the obligation to righteousness (literally *free from righteousness*): Paul means either that unbelievers feel no obligation to obey God or that they are unable to do so. But the freedom that they boast of actually makes them slaves to sin.

Romans 6:21

death: Throughout [chapters 5-8](#), Paul uses *death* to describe the eternal consequences of sin ([5:12](#), [14](#), [15](#), [17](#), [21](#); [6:16](#), [23](#); [7:5](#), [9-10](#), [13](#), [24](#); [8:2](#), [6](#), [13](#)). This language refers back to God's warning to Adam and Eve ([Genesis 2:17](#)). This death is not mainly physical. It means human separation from God's fellowship or union with God. If not reversed through faith in Christ and, it will last forever.

Romans 7:1

- Both Jewish Christians and many Gentile Christians were familiar with the law. Jewish people were taught the law of Moses from birth. Many Gentiles in the church at Rome had previously been God-fearers. These were Gentiles who were interested in Judaism and regularly attended the synagogue.
- *the law has authority over a man only as long as he lives*: Paul might be referencing a well-known Jewish saying. One rabbinic tradition says, "If a person is dead, he is free from the Torah and the fulfilling of the commandments" (*Babylonian Shabbat* 30a; *baraita Shabbat* 151).

Romans 7:2-3

These verses are not an allegory, in which every part of the story has a separate theological meaning. Paul uses a simple illustration to make two main points:

1. Death can free a person from the law.
2. Ending one relationship can allow a person to start a new one.

Paul applies this example in [7:4](#).

Romans 7:4

died to the law: This means they are no longer bound by it. Paul often describes the law of Moses as representing the old system of sin and death. However, through their union with Christ in his death, Christians are set free.

Romans 7:5

- *the flesh*: The word *flesh* can sometimes refer to the human body in a neutral way. For example, Paul speaks of Christ coming "in the flesh" (see [8:3](#)). More often, however, Paul uses *flesh* in a negative sense. It describes human life lived apart from God. To *live according to the flesh* means to be ruled by sin and opposed to God.
- *the sinful passions aroused by the law*: God's law is good in itself (see [7:12](#)). However, because people have sinful hearts (inner desires that go against God), the law can cause sinful desires to appear. When people live in rebellion against God, his commands can cause a desire to do the opposite of what he commands.

Romans 7:6

the written code (literally *the letter*): Paul uses this phrase to refer to the law of Moses. God carved this law on stone tablets consisting of individual letters (see [2:29](#); [2 Corinthians 3:5-7](#)).

Romans 7:7-25

What then (see study note on 6:1): Paul has just spoken in strong terms about the law. Now he explains that God's law is good. He does this to prevent people from thinking that the law itself is evil.

Romans 7:8

- *Sin, seizing its opportunity through the commandment:* The word *opportunity* is a military term for a position seized in enemy territory that becomes a base of operations (see [7:11](#)). By expressing God's demands, the commandments provoke rebellion within people controlled by sin. God's commandments become a chance for sin to achieve its harmful goals.
- *apart from the law, sin is dead:* The law, by plainly expressing God's will, makes people more accountable than they would be without it. The law of Moses did not solve Israel's sin problem but revealed and made it worse. This is always the effect that God's law, by itself, has on people controlled by sin.

Romans 7:9

- *Once I was alive apart from the law:* Paul might be referring to his early childhood, before he fully understood the law's demands.
- *but when the commandment came:* Paul's experience with the law as he matured reflects everyone's experience. With the law, we have more accountability to God. This gives sin power and leads to greater judgment ([7:10](#); see [4:15](#); [5:14](#), [20](#)).

Romans 7:10

The Old Testament promised a blessed and secure life to those who obeyed the law (for example, [Leviticus 18:5](#), quoted in [Romans 10:5](#)). However, people inherit a strong tendency to sin because of the effects of Adam's sin. So, when God's commands come to us, we often resist and disobey them. So, instead of bringing life, the law only reveals our lost and vulnerable spiritual condition. We need God to change our desires because the law cannot provide this inner change.

Romans 7:11

sin ... deceived me: Paul uses language similar to [Genesis 3:13](#). He may be thinking about the first human disobedience.

Romans 7:17

it is no longer I who do it: Paul is not avoiding responsibility for his sin (see also [7:20](#)). Instead, he explains that he truly wants to do what the law commands. Because of this, something else must be causing him to act in the opposite way. That cause is sin living in him. Paul describes a conflict between what he wants to do and what he actually does.

Romans 7:18

in my flesh: See study note on 6:19. This phrase may refer to Paul's former life before God redeemed him. It may also refer to a part of Paul that is still connected to this world and resists God's will.

Romans 7:21

the principle (literally *law*): Paul is referring to something that happens again and again. The struggle between wanting to do what is right and doing what is wrong shows a repeated pattern in human life.

Romans 7:22

in my inner being: Greek writers used this phrase to refer to the inner life of a person. It points to the spiritual part of a human being that does not pass away (compare [2 Corinthians 4:16](#); [Ephesians 3:16](#)).

Romans 7:23

another law ... the law: Paul uses the word play with *law* in these verses ([7:22](#)). Opposing God's *law* is *another law*, a ruling power that stops Paul from following God's *law*, even though he fully agrees with it.

Romans 7:24

this body of death: Sin affects the whole person. It especially shapes how people live and act in the physical world.

Romans 8:1

Therefore, there is now no condemnation: Paul concludes from the arguments in chapters [5-7](#) that neither sin nor the law can prevent Christians from gaining eternal life.

Paul confidently declares that people who belong to Christ Jesus do not need to fear condemnation for their sins.

Romans 8:2

the power (literally *the law*) of the life-giving Spirit: This reference to *power* or *law* could refer to the law of Moses, which the Spirit can use to produce life. But because Paul does not portray the law as a life-giving entity, “law” here, as in [7:23](#), probably means *principle* or *power*. The Holy Spirit is a power that frees the believer from the power of sin that leads to death.

Romans 8:3

our sinful nature: See study note on 6:19. • in a body like the bodies we sinners have: Jesus identified with sinful people so that he could be their representative and redeem them. Paul also implies that Jesus’ incarnate nature was not exactly like ours; born of a virgin through the power of the Holy Spirit, Jesus did not inherit a sinful nature from Adam. • a sacrifice for our sins: In the Greek Old Testament, this phrase frequently describes a sin offering, and three of the eight New Testament occurrences also have this meaning ([Heb 10:6, 8; 13:11](#)). Christ was the sin offering that brought forgiveness and turned away God’s wrath. God condemned sin in Christ, our substitute, so that we could escape condemnation.

Romans 8:4

just requirement of the law . . . fully satisfied for (Greek en, “in”) us: The Greek preposition en might indicate that the law is fulfilled *in* us because of our connection with Jesus Christ, who perfectly fulfilled the law for us. It could also mean that by setting us free from sin’s power, Jesus Christ enables us to please God and fulfill the true intention of the law. • As in the Old Testament (see [Gen 6:3, 12; Ps 78:39; Isa 40:6](#)), sinful nature refers to human weakness and bondage to sin (also in [Rom 8:5-9, 12-13](#)). Paul uses the phrase to describe the conflict between the ingrained human tendency to sin and the Holy Spirit.

Romans 8:5

think about sinful things: This phrase describes the general nature of a person’s will, not just the mental process of thought (see also [12:3; 15:5; Phil 2:2, 5](#)).

Romans 8:6

Peace here does not refer merely to peace of mind; instead, as opposed to death, it implies an objective state of peace with God (see study note on 5:1).

Romans 8:9

You are controlled by the Spirit: In contrast to unbelievers, who continue to live under the domination of Adam’s sinful nature, believers are directed in their lives by the Holy Spirit. The Spirit does not take away human initiative or make it impossible for believers to sin. However, as the most powerful force in believers’ lives, the Spirit makes it possible for them to resist the continuing power of sin.

Romans 8:10

the Spirit gives you life: The Spirit opposes sin (which leads to physical death) and brings resurrection from the dead.

Romans 8:11

by this same Spirit: The Holy Spirit is the agent of the resurrection of our bodies. Some manuscripts read “*because of the same Spirit*,” which would mean that the Spirit is the guarantee that our bodies will be raised (cp. [Eph 1:14](#)).

Romans 8:13

you will die: Death is the consequence of sin. Those who consistently yield to sin will suffer spiritual death (eternal condemnation). The presence of the Holy Spirit in the lives of believers makes it possible for them to turn away from sin. The result is eternal life (you will live).

Romans 8:14

children of God: In the Old Testament, this phrase referred to Israel, the people God called to be his own (see especially [Exod 4:22](#); [Jer 3:19](#); [31:9](#); [Hos 11:1](#)). Paul uses it to remind believers that they enjoy an intimate relationship with God and that they will inherit many of the promises and blessings given to Israel. Christians are no longer minors or slaves, but mature children with full rights (see [Gal 4:1–7](#)).

Romans 8:15

you received God’s Spirit when he adopted you as his own children: According to Greco-Roman customs of adoption, a man had the right to adopt a son and to confer on that child all the legal rights and privileges that would be given to a natural child. This practice extended even to the imperial family. The Roman emperor Julius Caesar adopted Octavian as his heir; Octavian, using the name Augustus, later ruled the Roman Empire. Paul’s concept of adoption is also rooted in the Old Testament and Judaism ([Exod 4:22](#); [Deut 1:31](#); [Hos 11:1](#); see also [Rom 9:4](#); [Gal 4:5](#); [Eph 1:5](#)). • Abba: This word was used in an intimate family context (“Daddy”). Jesus used this word to address God ([Mark 14:36](#)); all those who become children of God through Jesus have the privilege of addressing God in the same way.

Romans 8:17

Jesus is heir to all of God’s promises ([Mark 12:1–12](#); [Gal 3:18–19](#); [Heb 1:2](#)), and as those who belong to Jesus, we share with him in that glorious inheritance. However, just as it was for Jesus, our path to glory is also marked by suffering. We experience the difficulties that come from striving to live righteously in a world dominated by sin ([2 Cor 1:5](#); [Phil 1:29](#); [3:10](#)).

Romans 8:19–21

All creation includes animals, plants, and the earth itself. Paul follows Old Testament precedent (see especially [Ps 65:12–13](#); [Isa 24:4](#); [Jer 4:28](#); [12:4](#)) by personifying the created world. • waiting eagerly . . . looks forward: Just as the entire world was harmed by Adam’s fall into sin, it will share in the blessings that God has promised his people (e.g., [Isa 4:2](#), [Rev 21:1–2](#)).

Romans 8:22

The pains of childbirth is a metaphor for the longing of creation (see also [Matt 24:8](#); [Mark 13:8](#); [John 16:20–22](#)).

Romans 8:23

we believers also groan: “Groaning” expresses a frustrated longing for God’s deliverance from the difficulties and oppression of this life (see [Exod 3:7](#); [Lam 1:22](#); [Ezek 24:17](#); [2 Cor 5:2](#)). • we have the Holy Spirit within us as a foretaste of future glory (literally *we have the first harvest of the Spirit*): In the Old Testament, the phrase *first harvest* or *firstfruits* often describes the offering of the first and best part of a harvest to God (see [Exod 23:19](#); [Lev 2:12](#); [23:10](#); cp. [1 Cor 15:20](#), [23](#)). The Holy Spirit is God’s pledge that he will see his work in us through to its conclusion (see [Eph 1:14](#)). • Although we have already been adopted by God as his children, the full rights of that adoption—our inheritance (see [Rom 8:17](#))—are not yet ours. In this life, Christians live in tension between the “already” of redemption and the “not yet” of the glory to be revealed.

Romans 8:26

groanings that cannot be expressed in words: This might refer to speech that does not take the form of human language, such as when believers, uncertain of what to pray, utter meaningless sounds in prayer. The groanings in question are the Spirit's, not ours. When we do not know how to pray, the Spirit is interceding for us before God.

Romans 8:30

gave them his glory: Elsewhere in this passage, the *glory* Christians will experience is consistently in the future ([8:18](#), [21](#), [23](#)). The past tense here refers to God's past decision to glorify us in the future. We have not yet entered into our inheritance, but the Father has irrevocably determined to give us his glory.

Romans 8:31

such wonderful things: Paul is referring to everything he has taught in chs [5-8](#) about the blessings and sense of assurance that believers receive from their relationship with God.

Romans 8:32

did not spare even his own Son: Behind this language is the story about Abraham's willingness to offer his son Isaac ([Gen 22:12](#), [16](#)). Isaac, however, was not actually sacrificed. God's not sparing his only Son went the full course: He handed him over to the shameful and painful death of crucifixion.

Romans 9:1-11.36

In this section, Paul takes up the problem raised by the unbelief of so many Jews. If God had promised salvation to Israel yet so few Jews were being saved, how could Jesus truly be the fulfillment of God's plan ([9:1-5](#))? In his response to this objection, Paul cites the Old Testament as evidence that God had always intended to save only a remnant of Israel ([9:6-29](#)), and he faults the Jews for refusing to embrace Christ ([9:30-10:21](#)). Paul then shows that God has not discarded Israel from his plan of salvation. Many Jews have already

believed in Christ ([11:1-10](#)), and many more will believe in the future ([11:12-26](#)).

Romans 9:2-3

Paul does not explicitly say why he has such bitter sorrow for his Jewish brothers and sisters. Yet his willingness to become cursed on their behalf if that would save them makes clear that the failure of most Jews to respond to Jesus and be saved stimulated his agony (see also [10:1](#)).

Romans 9:3

I would be willing to be forever cursed (Greek anathema): Anathema is used in the Greek Old Testament to translate a Hebrew expression that means "set apart for God," which usually has the negative sense of something destined to be destroyed as an offering to God (see [Lev 27:28-29](#); [Josh 6:17-18](#); [7:1](#), [11-13](#); [22:20](#); [1 Sam 15:3](#); [1 Chr 2:7](#)). Paul knows that he cannot, in fact, be cut off from Christ. Paul is echoing the offer of Moses, who pled with God to kill him but to spare the people ([Exod 32:30-32](#)).

Romans 9:4

Up to this point in Romans, Paul has called the Jewish people *Jews*. His shift to people of Israel, here and throughout most of chs [9-11](#), is significant. *Jew* connotes national identity, but *Israel* emphasizes the covenant relationship of the people with God. • chosen to be God's adopted children: The Old Testament called Israel God's *son* or *child* to emphasize that God had selected Israel to be his own people (e.g., [Exod 4:22](#); [Jer 3:19](#); [31:9](#); [Hos 11:1](#)). Israel's adopted status meant that they received God's blessing and promises, not that they were necessarily saved. • covenants: The Old Testament includes several covenants between God and the people of Israel: one with Abraham ([Gen 17](#)), one with the nation through Moses at Mount Sinai ([Exod 19-24](#)), and one with David ([2 Sam 7:8-16](#); [23:5](#)).

Romans 9:5

Christ came from the people of Israel, and God first made his promises of salvation to them.

Romans 9:6

are truly members of God's people (literally *are Israel*): "Israel" can refer to the people of Israel in a biological sense, i.e., everyone descended from Jacob. But in the latter part of the Old Testament and in Judaism, the idea of a "righteous remnant" within Israel developed (see [Isa 11:10–16](#)). On at least one occasion in the New Testament, Israel refers to everyone, Jew and Gentile, who belongs to God in a spiritual sense ([Gal 6:16](#)). Paul is stating that there is now an "Israel within Israel," a community consisting of both Jews and Gentiles who truly believe (cp. [Rom 11:16–17](#); [Gal 6:16](#)).

Romans 9:7

This quotation is from [Gen 21:12](#), which God spoke to Abraham when he was reluctant to follow Sarah's advice to banish his son Ishmael, who was born to the slave woman Hagar. God assured Abraham that Sarah's child, Isaac, was the son through whom God's promises would be fulfilled.

Romans 9:10–11

she gave birth to twins: No human circumstances differentiated Isaac's sons, Jacob and Esau. Not only were they born to the same mother, but they were also conceived at the same time. Instead, Paul argues, the difference between them was of God's choosing.

Romans 9:12

"Your older son will serve your younger son": God spoke these words to Rebekah before the twins were born ([Gen 25:23](#)). As the older of the twins, Esau was Isaac's natural heir. But Esau sold his birthright to Jacob and ceded his position to his brother in fulfillment of God's promise.

Romans 9:13

"I loved Jacob, but I rejected (literally *hated*) Esau": Paul quotes [Mal 1:2–3](#), where Jacob, whose other name is Israel ([Gen 32:28](#)), stands for the nation of Israel, and Esau stands for Edom. Here, Paul is

referring to them as individuals. Just as love can sometimes express a choice, so hate can express rejection. The story of Jacob and Esau illustrates how the sovereign God chooses his own people.

Romans 9:14–16

God's choice is not unfair because he owes nothing to his sinful creatures (see study note on 4:4–5).

Romans 9:15

This quotation from [Exod 33:19](#) focuses on God's nature: God is free from obligation or constraint in bestowing mercy on people.

Romans 9:17

God told Pharaoh: At God's direction, Moses had asked Pharaoh to let the people of Israel leave Egypt for their own land ([Exod 9:16](#)). When Pharaoh stubbornly refused, God displayed miracle after miracle to convince Israel, Pharaoh, and the Egyptians of God's power and authority (see [Exod 6:7](#); [7:5](#); [9:14–16](#); [14:31](#)).

Romans 9:18

he chooses to harden the hearts of others so they refuse to listen: Pharaoh refused to let Israel go because his heart was hardened. God hardened Pharaoh's heart ([Exod 9:12](#)), and Pharaoh hardened his own heart ([Exod 8:15](#)).

Romans 9:20–21

See [Isa 29:16](#); [45:9–10](#).

Romans 9:24–26

God was free to select people from the Jews who would have a true spiritual relationship with him; similarly, he was also free to choose some from the Gentiles to be saved as well. Paul uses the prophecy of Hosea to reinforce his point. Hosea predicted that God would renew his mercy to the ten northern tribes that had rebelled against God and

were under his judgment. Paul saw a principle that applies to Gentiles as well. • Those who were not my people: See study note on 10:19.

Romans 9:27-28

only a remnant will be saved: So many Israelites had turned from God that the Old Testament prophets spoke of a true spiritual Israel within the larger nation of Israel (see [Isa 11:10-16](#)). The remnant would receive salvation, while the rest of the Israelites would suffer condemnation.

Romans 9:29

The destruction of the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah ([Gen 19](#)) is a poignant illustration of the reality and severity of God's judgment.

Romans 9:31

who tried so hard to get right with God by keeping the law (literally *who pursued the law of righteousness*): *Law of righteousness* is an idiom that means "righteousness through the law."

Romans 9:32-33

The great rock in their path is Christ. People either build on him by putting their faith in him, or they stumble over his message that faith, and not human works, is the key to getting right with God.

Romans 9:33

This quotation is from [Isa 8:14](#); [28:16](#). These two texts, along with [Ps 118:22](#), are also quoted together in [1 Pet 2:6-8](#). The early church likely had a collection of messianic "stone" quotations from the Old Testament that they used to illuminate the significance of Christ (see also [Matt 21:42](#)).

Romans 10:2

Zeal denotes a passionate and commendable commitment to God and his purposes (see [Num 25:6-13](#)). But in Paul's day Jewish zeal was

misdirected because it failed to understand that Jesus Christ is the pinnacle of God's plan. (For Paul's own misdirected zeal before his conversion to Christ, see [Acts 9:1-2](#); [Gal 1:13-14](#).)

Romans 10:3

God's way of making people right with himself: See [1:17](#); [3:21-26](#). Paul uses this phrase to explain Israel's failure in terms basic to the gospel. God manifested his righteousness through the ministry of Christ, but most Jews did not understand it, partly because they were so focused on the law as a way of securing their own righteousness.

Romans 10:4

The function of the law was to point forward and prepare the way for the Messiah; Jesus' coming does not destroy the law but fulfills all of its requirements, so that the primary requirement for God's people is to believe in him (see [3:31](#); [Matt 5:17-18](#)).

Romans 10:5

requires obedience to all of its commands: See [Lev 18:5](#), where these words encouraged the Israelites to obey the law in order to enjoy long life and prosperity in the land that God was giving them (see also [Lev 26:3-13](#); [Deut 28:1-14](#)). Paul sees the implication that if people want to be right with God through the law, they can only do so by obeying all of it.

Romans 10:6-8

Here Paul quotes three phrases from [Deut 30:12-14](#) dealing with the law, and he applies them to the Good News about Christ. We do not need to go up to heaven to find Christ (and thus to be made right with God), because God has already brought him down to earth as a man. Nor do we need to go down to the place of the dead to find Christ, because God has already raised him from the dead. To find Christ, we must simply believe in the message that is close at hand.

Romans 10:13

Paul quotes [Joel 2:32](#), where the Lord in Hebrew is *Yahweh*, the personal name of God (see [Exod 3:15](#)). However, as [Rom 10:12](#) makes clear, *the Lord* in Romans is Jesus Christ. This verse shows that Christians from the time of the apostles have associated Jesus with God.

Romans 10:14

It is natural to presume that the pronoun they refers to “all who call on him” from [10:12](#) or “everyone” from [10:13](#). While this verse probably does refer to all people, it also continues the accusation against Israel from [10:2-3](#) (see [10:18](#)). Paul argues that Israel was in a position to know what God was doing through Jesus Christ, so they were culpable for their failure to understand or accept it. Israel was guilty both of failing to understand God’s plan in light of Christ ([10:3-4](#)) and of focusing so much attention on the law that they missed Christ when he arrived ([9:30-32](#)).

Romans 10:18

Yes, they have: Paul quotes [Ps 19:4](#) to show that the message of Good News was universally available through creation. And by the time Paul wrote Romans, early Christian missionaries had spread the Good News through most of the Roman Empire. Most Jews would have had ample opportunity to hear the message.

Romans 10:19

rouse your jealousy . . . provoke your anger: This quotation from [Deut 32:21](#) concerns God’s punishment of Israel for their idolatry. In Paul’s day, Israel remained guilty of idolatry because it put the law in place of God himself. God’s punishment involved using the Gentiles, people who are not even a nation, to make Israel jealous and angry ([Rom 11:12-32](#) elaborates on this theme).

Romans 10:20

This quotation is from [Isa 65:1](#). In Isaiah, the words people who were not looking for me refer to the

people of Israel. As in [Rom 9:25-26](#), Paul applies them to the Gentiles to show that God has opened the way for them to be a part of the people of God.

Romans 11:2

chose from the very beginning: Before the people of Israel could do anything to earn their status, God selected them to be his people based on his grace alone. • Elijah the prophet: In [1 Kgs 19:1-18](#), the apostate King Ahab had slaughtered many of the Lord’s prophets, and Ahab’s wife Jezebel threatened Elijah with the same fate. Elijah fled to the wilderness, where he bemoaned his fate. God responded with the assurance that many faithful people remained. Paul found the present situation to be somewhat parallel. While many Jews did not believe, and some were even hostile, God was (and is) still working to preserve a believing remnant.

Romans 11:5

a few of the people of Israel (literally *a remnant*): Paul returns to the Old Testament concept of the remnant that he used in [9:27-29](#). This solid core of godly Israelites represents God’s pledge of his continuing faithfulness to his promises and to his people.

Romans 11:7-8

the hearts of the rest were hardened: This is God’s own work; God has put them into a deep sleep and shut their eyes. See [Acts 13:46-48](#); [18:6](#).

Romans 11:11

so God made salvation available to the Gentiles: The offer of salvation to the Gentiles is the purpose, not just the result, of Israel’s disobedience. Paul emphasizes that God had the salvation of Gentiles in view all along, and, ultimately, the salvation of many Jews as well. • he wanted his own people to become jealous: The theme of jealousy comes from [Deut 32:21](#), which Paul quoted in [Rom 10:19](#). The sight of Gentiles enjoying the blessings of salvation that God had promised to Israel would spur Jews to desire salvation so they could participate in those blessings as well.

Romans 11:13–14

you Gentiles: Paul addresses the Gentile Christians in Rome with the practical goal of rebuking them for thinking too highly of themselves ([11:20](#)), especially in relation to their Jewish brothers and sisters. He shows that their enjoyment of salvation depends entirely on God's kindness ([11:22](#)) and that God's final goal is to stimulate repentance among the Jews ([11:23](#)). • I stress this: Paul devoted himself to the conversion of Gentiles because he knew that their salvation would ultimately lead to salvation for Jews as well.

Romans 11:15

The context emphasizes God's role in hardening many Jews ([11:7–10](#)), so the phrase their rejection likely means God's rejection of the unbelieving Jews. • Their acceptance then refers to God's acceptance of Jews into his Kingdom (see also [14:3](#) and [15:7](#)). • While the phrase life for those who were dead could refer to the new spiritual life that comes to the Jews as a result of their conversion to Christ (see [6:13](#)), the language more naturally suggests the physical resurrection from the dead that occurs when Christ returns in glory (see, e.g., [1 Thes 4:13–18](#)).

Romans 11:16

the entire batch of dough is holy because the portion given as an offering is holy: This imagery comes from [Num 15:17–21](#), where God commanded the Israelites to take part of their first batch of dough and set it aside as a gift. God's promises to and blessings on Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were like a down payment, guaranteeing the completion of God's work among his people.

Romans 11:17–24

In Paul's extended metaphor, God's special olive tree refers to the people of God. The image is a natural one, because the olive tree is the most widely cultivated fruit tree in the Mediterranean basin, and it was already used as a symbol of Israel in the Old Testament ([Jer 11:16](#); [Hos 14:5–6](#)). Paul refers to the Gentile Christians as branches from a

wild olive tree because they were not originally included among the people of God.

Romans 11:18

You are just a branch, not the root: By the time Paul wrote to the church in Rome, it was composed mainly of Gentiles, a common situation in the early Christian communities. This dominant role led many Gentile Christians to brag about their status, while treating Jews and their religious heritage with disdain. Paul reminds the Gentile believers that they enjoy God's blessings only because they have been included in the one people of God, who are rooted in God's promises to Israel.

Romans 11:20

fear what could happen: In Scripture, fear often means a reverential awe of God that includes the recognition that we must one day stand before him in judgment (see [2 Cor 5:11](#); [7:1](#), [11](#), [15](#); [Phil 2:12](#); [Col 3:22](#)).

Romans 11:22

if you stop trusting, you also will be cut off: Scripture consistently emphasizes that only believers who persevere to the end will be saved. However, Paul's warning leads to debate over the theological implications of his statement. Some think that it implies that genuine believers can stop believing and therefore not be saved in the end. Others argue that we should not press the metaphor so far and that Paul is referring to people who appear to be believers but whose lack of real faith ultimately reveals itself.

Romans 11:24

by nature . . . contrary to nature: The usual method of enhancing the yield of olive trees involved grafting a shoot from a cultivated tree onto a wild olive tree to benefit from the wild tree's vigor. By grafting wild olive branches (Gentiles) into the cultivated olive tree (the people of God), God has done what is contrary to nature.

Romans 11:25

Paul usually uses the word *mystery* to refer to an event of the last days that has already been determined by God. Such a *mystery* already exists in heaven and is revealed to God's people in the Christian era (see [16:25](#); [1 Cor 2:1, 7](#); [4:1](#); [15:51](#); [Eph 1:9](#); [3:3](#), [4](#), [9](#); [6:19](#); [Col 1:26, 27](#); [2:2](#); [4:3](#); [1 Tim 3:9, 16](#)). Here, the mystery is the relationship of Jews and Gentiles in the plan of salvation, which is at the heart of this entire passage ([Rom 11:11-32](#)).

Romans 11:26-27

The phrase *all Israel* could refer to the total of all believers, both Jewish and Gentile; with this meaning, and so would describe the way that God works to bring salvation to all his people. Alternatively, *all Israel* could refer to the total of all Jews destined to believe throughout the Christian era, or to a significant number of Jews who turn to Christ in the last days. With the last meaning, *and so* would have a sequential meaning—after the full number of Gentiles comes to Christ, *then* the full number of Jews will be saved. It does not mean all Jewish people (see [2:17-29](#)). • In the Old Testament, The one who rescues is the Lord. Paul almost surely is referring to Jesus Christ (see [1 Thes 1:10](#)). • from Jerusalem: The Hebrew text of [Isa 59:20](#) says that the redeemer will come to Jerusalem. Paul might have changed the wording to represent Jesus' first coming from among the people of Israel or to speak of the second coming when Jesus will return from the heavenly Jerusalem (see [Heb 12:22](#)).

Romans 11:32

have mercy on everyone: *Everyone* has the sense of "all kinds of people." In the context of Romans, and especially this chapter, it refers to the inclusion of Gentiles alongside Jews.

Romans 11:36

everything comes from him and exists by his power: This statement is similar to statements found among Greek Stoic philosophers in their descriptions of God. Paul regularly draws on literature from the Greco-Roman world to present

and clarify the truth about God and his purposes (cp. [Acts 17:24-29](#)).

Romans 12:1

Your bodies refers to the whole person in contact with the world, not just the physical body. • because of all he has done for you: As described in chs [1-11](#). • This is truly the way to worship him (or *This is your spiritual worship*; or *This is your reasonable service*): This phrase has at least three possible meanings: (1) Our sacrifice is *reasonable* in light of all God's mercies; (2) our sacrifice is *spiritual*, not the offering of an animal but of ourselves in spiritual service; or (3) our sacrifice is *intelligent*, offered with complete awareness of God's goodness to us.

Romans 12:1-15:13

This section of Romans sets out the moral and ethical demands of the Good News. God's gift of salvation in Christ requires a response. God is not satisfied simply with forgiving our sin; he wants to transform our lives. Most of what Paul teaches concerning the moral duties of believers is paralleled in other letters. However, it also seems clear that he has chosen issues pertinent to the situation in Rome—most notably, the dispute between people who are weak in faith and people who are strong in faith ([14:1-15:13](#)).

Romans 12:2

this world (literally *this age*): The division of history into two ages was typical of the Jewish worldview. Early Christians adapted this point of view, identifying the coming of Christ as the time when the new age of salvation began. Unexpectedly, however, the new age did not bring an end to the old age. The old way of thinking and living continues, and it is a source of temptation even to Christians who seek to conform their lives to the values of the new age.

Romans 12:3

by the faith God has given us: Or *by the faith God has given you*; or *by the standard of our God-given faith*. Whether Paul is referring to the amount of faith

each of us has been given or to the Christian faith that we all hold in common, we need to assess ourselves accurately by this measure and not be vain about the abilities God has given us.

Romans 12:4–5

so it is with Christ's body: The parallel between the human body and the church—the body of Christ—is also found in [1 Cor 12](#). This metaphor provides an effective picture of unity and diversity in the church (cp. Livy, *History* 2.32; Epictetus, *Discourses* 2.10.4–5).

Romans 12:6

The ability to prophesy was one of the most important of the New Testament gifts (see also [1 Cor 12:28](#); [Eph 4:11](#)). Although prophets are mentioned in several passages in Acts as predicting the future (see [Acts 11:28](#); [21:10–12](#)), the prophet's most fundamental responsibility is to communicate God's message to the community of believers ([1 Cor 12:3, 24–25, 29–30](#); see also [1 Cor 14:1–40](#)). • as much faith as God has given you (literally *in proportion to the faith*): *Proportion* (Greek *analogia*) is a word drawn from mathematics and logic, where it refers to the correct proportions in a relationship among things, quantities, or ideas. Paul uses the phrase to remind prophets to make sure that their utterances are in right proportion to faith, whether the amount of individual faith the prophet has been given, or the Christian faith in general (see study note on Rom 12:3). This passage has given theology the phrase *the analogy of faith*, which refers to the importance of bringing the interpretation of any particular passage into line with the teaching of all of Scripture.

Romans 12:7

teacher: The gift of teaching comes third in the list of gifts in [1 Cor 12:28](#) and fifth in [Eph 4:11](#). While prophets communicate to the community a message received directly from God, teachers address the church on the basis of studying the word of God.

Romans 12:8

give generously: See also [2 Cor 8:2](#); [9:11](#), [13](#).

Romans 12:9–21

The many injunctions in these verses do not follow a neat logical arrangement. The overall topic, stated at the beginning, is sincere love. Paul shows how we are to love both those inside the church ([12:10, 13, 15–16](#)) and those outside the church ([12:14, 17–21](#)).

Romans 12:10

genuine affection: Literally *brotherly love*. Christians are to love each other with the mutual love and commitment that are found within a healthy family.

Romans 12:11

but work hard and serve the Lord enthusiastically: As Christians, we are to be passionate about our faith and eager to fulfill our ministry to others within the church.

Romans 12:12

The three commands in this verse are related. By rejoicing in confident hope, we can be patient in trouble. Continually praying is essential if we desire to have this attitude toward the difficulties of life (see also [8:24–27](#)).

Romans 12:13

be ready to help them: The verb Paul uses is related to the familiar Greek word *koinōnia* ("fellowship"). When needs arise among our Christian brothers and sisters, we are not just to meet their needs; we should also enter into fellowship with these fellow Christians in ways that extend beyond material gifts.

Romans 12:14

The exhortations in this verse closely resemble two sayings of Jesus ([Matt 5:44](#); [Luke 6:27-28](#)). Although Paul does not introduce the commands as a quotation, he is almost certainly alluding to these sayings of Christ. Perhaps the words were so well known that he did not need to specify the source. The teaching of [Rom 12-13](#) has many parallels with the teaching of Jesus.

Romans 12:16

All three exhortations in this verse use the Greek word *phroneō* (think). Paul addresses the need for right Christian thinking when it comes to our relationships with other Christians. • Live in harmony: Literally *Think the same things*. • Don't be too proud: Literally *Don't think arrogant things*.

Romans 12:18

Do all that you can: Paul recognizes that our efforts to live at peace with others will sometimes be frustrated by our own moral constraints or by other people's unwillingness to be reconciled to us.

Romans 12:20-21

A simple act of Christian kindness can often bring a hostile person to repentance before God and restore fellowship between people.

Romans 13:1-2

The basic command of [13:1-7](#) is to submit to governing authorities. In God's ordering of the world, we answer to those in positions of authority. Our submission to them will usually take the form of obedience. However, because God stands over all governments, our submission to governing authorities must always be in terms of our ultimate submission to God (see [Acts 4:19-20](#)). The Roman Christians might have been resisting government (see study note on Rom 13:6) based on a false understanding of the Good News, as if no longer copying "the behavior and customs of this world" ([12:2](#)) meant that they could ignore earthly institutions. • placed there by God: Scripture consistently teaches that God is actively involved in

raising up and casting down human governments and leaders ([1 Sam 2:6-10](#); [12:8](#); [Prov 8:15-16](#); [Isa 41:2-4](#); [45:1-7](#); [Jer 21:7](#), [10](#); [27:5-6](#); [Dan 2:21](#), [37-38](#); [4:17](#)). God instituted governing authorities, so rebelling against them is rebelling against God, who will respond with judgment ([Rom 13:2](#)).

Romans 13:3

the authorities do not strike fear in people who are doing right: Paul presents a positive picture of the governing authorities, describing them in terms of what God has appointed them to do. He does not touch on situations where leaders punish those who do good and reward those who do evil, although he was certainly aware of such situations from Old Testament and Jewish history, from the experience of Jesus and the other apostles, and from Greco-Roman affairs. Here, Paul confines himself to discussing the appropriate response to governing authorities who live according to their calling.

Romans 13:4

- Servant: The New Testament often uses this Greek word (*diakonos*) to describe Christians serving God in different roles. In non-religious Greek, *diakonos* can also refer to a city official. A government and its leaders serve God by administering justice, whether they realize it or not.
- *he does not carry the sword in vain*: Here, *the sword* might be a metaphor for any punishment. Some interpreters believe it means human governments, under God's authority, have the right to use capital punishment. (Capital punishment is the practice of killing someone as a legal penalty for certain crimes.)

Romans 13:5

The two reasons for submission sum up the argument of [13:1-4](#) in reverse order: to avoid punishment relates to [13:3-4](#), while to keep a clear

conscience refers to [13:1-2](#). • The word conscience (Greek *suneidēsis*) refers to the painful knowledge of wrongdoing. Christians know about their duty to submit to governing authorities, and their failure to do so would bring the pain of a guilty conscience.

Romans 13:6

Pay your taxes: Jesus referred to paying taxes in his famous pronouncement about the disciples' relationship to government ([Matt 22:21](#)). A tax revolt occurred in Rome at about the time that Paul was writing, so Paul's whole discussion of the Christian's responsibility to government might have been sparked by his knowledge that Roman Christians were participating in this tax revolt (see Tacitus, *Annals* 13).

Romans 13:8

The idea of obligation is the hinge that connects [13:1-7](#) and [13:8-10](#). Christians are to "give to everyone what [they] owe them" ([13:7](#)), and Christians always owe love to their neighbors. • Owe nothing to anyone: Debts are not sinful but should be avoided and, if incurred, should be promptly repaid so that the believer is free to serve in love (see [Prov 22:7](#)). • love one another: Believers are called to love all those they encounter ([Rom 12:14-21](#); [Luke 10:25-37](#)), but the phrase especially emphasizes the love that each believer owes to other believers. • you will fulfill the requirements of God's law: This teaching closely follows Jesus' teaching in [Matt 22:34-40](#).

Romans 13:8-10

These verses discuss how believers relate to other people. If we truly love others, our actions will reflect all the commandments in the law that concern our relationships with other people.

Romans 13:11

The New Testament often speaks of salvation as the final victory over sin and death that believers will experience when Jesus returns in glory (see [5:9-10](#)).

Romans 13:12-13

the day of salvation: The word *day* reflects two sources. First, the Old Testament repeatedly predicts the *day of the Lord* when God's plan culminates (see [Isa 13:4-13](#); [Jer 3:18](#); [30:8-9](#); [Joel 2:1-32](#); [Obad 1:15-18](#)). Second, the tradition of moral instruction in the ancient world associated light/daytime with good and darkness/nighttime with evil. The Greeks, Romans, and Jews all used this contrast. Because believers belong to the day they should be living out its values, avoiding the dark deeds that are typical of nighttime.

Romans 14:1

Being weak in faith means having scruples against doing certain things that Christian liberty would allow. In Rome, most of the weak in faith were Jewish Christians whose consciences did not give them liberty from certain requirements of Jewish law.

Romans 14:1-15:7

Paul moves to a specific issue that was causing conflict in the church at Rome. The church in Rome was embroiled in a dispute between people who were weak in faith and people who were strong (see [15:1](#)) regarding certain practices. Throughout this section, Paul instructs believers to be tolerant toward others and their practices; he is convinced that people on both sides of the issue are genuine believers, and he does not think the issues they are fighting over are essential to the faith.

Romans 14:2

The weak in faith apparently believed that they should eat only vegetables. Their conviction probably stemmed from a concern to maintain Jewish ritual purity in the midst of a pagan culture. These Jewish Christians were following the lead of Daniel and his friends, who refused to eat the rich food and wine that the king of Babylon offered them ([Dan 1:3-16](#)). Other Jewish sources reveal that pious Jews often restricted their diets in pagan cultures because they could never be sure that meat had been slaughtered according to Jewish requirements.

Romans 14:3-4

look down on . . . condemn: The “strong,” those who prided themselves on their enlightened freedom in Christ, looked with disdain on those they considered to be “weak.” The weak, in turn—certain that they were following the true route to piety—condemned the strong for their laxness. These attitudes, over different issues, are mirrored throughout the history of the Christian church. • God has accepted them: Both the weak and the strong are genuine believers, welcomed by God into his family. Therefore, they have no right to treat each other as if they do not belong ([14:4](#); see also [15:7](#)).

Romans 14:5

some think one day is more holy than another day, while others think every day is alike: The reference is probably to Jewish festival days and to the Sabbath; cp. [Col 2:16](#). With Christ’s provision of salvation, observance of the Sabbath in its original form is not required of Christians.

Romans 14:7

As the Lord’s servants ([14:4](#)), Christians are to look to God for guidance and seek to honor him in all things ([14:8](#)). Because we are ultimately accountable to him, our desire should always be to please him, not to live for ourselves.

Romans 14:9

Paul refers to standard early Christian teaching on the significance of Jesus’ death and resurrection (e.g., [2 Cor 5:15](#)). • of the living and of the dead (literally *of the dead and of the living*): The original word order matches the sequence of Jesus’ death and resurrection, the redemptive events that make Jesus our Lord.

Romans 14:10

we will all stand before the judgment seat of God: Paul reminds the Roman Christians that it is the Lord, not other Christians, who will ultimately judge all of us (cp. [2 Cor 5:10](#)).

Romans 14:11

This quotation is from [Isa 49:18](#); [45:23](#). In its original context, [Isa 45:23](#) is surrounded by assertions of God’s sovereignty ([Isa 45:22, 24](#)). Only the sovereign God has the right to stand in judgment ([Rom 14:10, 12](#)).

Romans 14:13

This verse acts as a bridge. Let’s stop condemning each other summarizes [14:1-12](#), while the concern about causing another believer to stumble and fall becomes the major emphasis of [14:14-23](#). • stumble and fall: This phrase originally applied to obstacles that could trip people as they walked, or to traps into which a person might fall. It is used metaphorically throughout the New Testament for behavior that might bring spiritual harm to another person (see [1 Cor 8:9, 13](#); [1 Jn 2:10](#); cp. [Matt 21:42-44](#); [Luke 20:17-18](#); [Rom 9:32-33](#); [1 Pet 2:8](#)).

Romans 14:14

no food, in and of itself, is wrong to eat (literally *nothing is common in itself*): The word *common* signals that the root concern that Paul was addressing was Jewish purity regulations. Jews described food as *common* if it was not clean (i.e., not kosher), thereby causing a Jew to become ritually impure (see [Lev 11](#); cp. [Mark 7:2, 5](#); [Acts 10:14](#)). Paul again follows the teaching of Jesus that “every kind of food is acceptable in God’s eyes” ([Mark 7:19](#)). • for that person it is wrong: The truth that no food is wrong to eat was not easy for pious Jews to accept because they had been raised to honor God by avoiding certain foods. Paul urges those who are strong in faith not to force others to violate their consciences (cp. [1 Cor 8:1-13](#)).

Romans 14:15

The word translated ruin (Greek *apollumi*, “destroy”) is often applied to eternal damnation (see [2:12](#); [Matt 10:28](#); [18:14](#); [Luke 9:24](#); [13:2-5](#); [John 3:16](#); [10:10, 28](#); [1 Cor 1:18-19](#); [Jas 4:12](#); [2 Pet 3:9](#)). By insisting on their freedom to eat whatever they want, the strong might cause sensitive Jewish Christians for whom Christ died to turn away from the faith.

Romans 14:20

The work of God refers both to the spiritual life of other Christians ([14:15](#)) and to the Christian community itself ([14:19](#)). The strong, with their dogged insistence on doing whatever they want, create division and disrupt God's intention to build a healthy and united community of believers.

Romans 14:21

or drink wine: Jews sometimes abstained from wine to avoid the appearance of ritual contamination, since wine was used in pagan religious celebrations (see [Dan 1:3-16](#)).

Romans 14:22

keep it between yourself and God: Paul did not contest the freedom of the strong believers, but he instructed them to limit the expression of their freedom out of love for fellow believers so that the whole Christian community could be built up. • Blessed are those who don't feel guilty: Guilt could come from harming the faith of the weak believers. Christian freedom is only worthwhile when it can be lived out without bringing such guilt.

Romans 14:23

If you do anything you believe is not right, you are sinning: God's word defines sin for us, yet sin also involves violating our conscience. The weak Christians in Rome did not yet believe in their own hearts that they could eat meat, drink wine, or ignore Jewish holy days; their consciences were still weak. They should not violate their consciences on these matters. Nor should the strong, by the power of their example or by their scorn, force weak Christians to do so.

Romans 15:1-4

We who are strong: Paul aligns himself with those he identifies as strong in faith, and he reveals that the division in the Roman church was not simply between Jews and Gentiles. Like Paul, some Jews had enlightened consciences and so were counted among the strong. Similarly, some Gentiles were so strongly influenced by Jewish teaching and

tradition that they were among the weak in faith. • must be considerate of those who are sensitive about things like this: This phrase is reminiscent of [Gal 6:2](#). Paul did not want the strong to simply put up with those who were weak in faith; rather the strong were to actively and sympathetically assist the weak in living out their Christian faith with integrity (see also [Gal 5:13-15](#)).

Romans 15:2

others (literally *the neighbor*): See [Lev 19:18](#), quoted in [Rom 13:9](#). Love for others should govern the conduct of people who are strong in faith.

Romans 15:3

This quotation is from [Ps 69:9](#). • A number of passages in the New Testament use [Psalm 69](#) to describe Jesus' suffering ([Matt 27:34](#); [Mark 15:35-36](#); [Luke 23:36](#); [John 15:25](#); [19:28-29](#)). Paul's quotation of just a small portion of that psalm evokes the whole experience of Jesus' suffering.

Romans 15:4

Such things were written in the Scriptures long ago to teach us: All that God caused to be recorded in the Old Testament has supreme relevance to believers, who experience the fulfillment of God's plan.

Romans 15:5-6

live in complete harmony: This phrase (see study note on 12:16) refers to the whole orientation of how someone thinks. A mindset of harmony is important for Christian unity (see [12:3-5](#), [16](#); [Phil 2:2-5](#)).

Romans 15:7

To accept each other means more than grudgingly putting up with each other. We are to welcome other believers, with all their flaws and sins, into our fellowship and treat them as family (see study note on 12:10), just as Christ has accepted us, with all our flaws and sins, into his fellowship and family ([5:8-11](#)).

Romans 15:8-9

Through Christ, God made it possible for Jews and Gentiles to join together to give glory to him in the new covenant people of God (see chs [9-11](#)). The issue of Jewish-Gentile relationships was fundamental to the dispute in the Roman church ([14:1-15:7](#)).

Romans 15:9-12

would join with Jews in praising God. Gentiles are now full members of God's people.

Romans 15:14

You know these things so well: Paul praises the Roman Christians, as he had in the opening of the letter (see [1:8-12](#)), demonstrating a gracious manner toward a church he had neither founded nor visited.

Romans 15:14-16:27

This final section contains elements common at the end of New Testament letters: a discussion of travel plans ([15:14-29](#)), requests for prayer ([15:30-33](#)), references to ministry associates ([16:1-2](#), [21-23](#)), greetings ([16:3-16](#)), and a doxology ([16:25-27](#)). Only the warning about false teachers ([16:17-19](#)) is a non-standard feature in this conclusion.

Romans 15:15-16

by God's grace: Paul emphasized that his role as apostle and teacher was because God had chosen him to lead in the formation of the Christian church (see also [1:5](#); [12:3](#); [1 Cor 3:10](#); [Gal 2:9](#); [Eph 3:2](#), [7](#), [8](#)).

Romans 15:16

special messenger: The Greek word (*leitourgos*, "servant" or "minister") could refer to almost any kind of servant, but Jews often applied the word to priests. Paul probably chose this word to emphasize the priestly nature of his ministry. •

you Gentiles: Paul stresses the Gentile flavor of the church in Rome (see also [1:6-7](#)). This does not mean that there were no Jews in the church (see [16:3-16](#)), but Gentiles had become the majority. • present you as an acceptable offering to God: Paul was fulfilling [Isa 66:19-20](#).

Romans 15:19

I have fully presented the Good News of Christ: Paul was not claiming that the work of evangelism had been completed in these regions. His point was that churches had been planted in enough major population centers so that those churches could carry on the work of evangelism themselves. Paul's own distinctive ministry of planting foundational and strategic churches had been fulfilled. • An arc drawn from Jerusalem all the way to Illyricum would include the areas where Paul had planted churches (southern Galatia, Asia Minor, Macedonia, and Greece). Illyricum was a Roman province that occupied most of the coastlands northeast of Italy along the Adriatic Sea, from modern-day Albania to Croatia.

Romans 15:24

I am planning to go to Spain: In Paul's day, "Spain" included the entire Iberian Peninsula (modern Spain and Portugal). Parts of the peninsula had been occupied by the Romans since 200 BC, but only within Paul's lifetime had the area been organized into a Roman province. Paul saw Spain, at the far end of the Mediterranean, as his final target in fulfilling the promise of [Isa 66:19-20](#). • you can provide for my journey: Spain was so far from Paul's previous sending church, Antioch in Syria, that he hoped the Roman church could serve as the logistical base for this future evangelistic effort.

Romans 15:25-28

I must go to Jerusalem to take a gift to the believers there: During his third missionary journey, Paul collected donations from the Gentile churches to help the believers in Jerusalem and to draw the two wings of the first-century church closer together (see also [1 Cor 16:1-2](#); [2 Cor 8-9](#)).

Romans 15:26

Paul founded churches in several prominent cities in Macedonia, including Philippi, Thessalonica, and Berea. In Achaia, Paul had preached in Athens and founded the church in Corinth (see [Acts 16–18](#)). • the poor among the believers in Jerusalem: Jewish Christians in Jerusalem were suffering from famines that had hit the area (see [Acts 11:27–30](#)) and also because their faith in Christ caused them to be ostracized from Jewish society.

Romans 15:27

they owe a real debt: Gentile Christians owe their spiritual existence to God's work among the Israelites (see [11:17–24](#)).

Romans 15:31

Pray that I will be rescued from those in Judea who refuse to obey God: See [Acts 21–22](#). God preserved Paul's life and used the circumstances of his arrest in Jerusalem to take him precisely where he planned to go—Rome.

Romans 15:33

Some manuscripts do not include Amen. One very early manuscript places the doxology ([16:25–27](#)) here. This has led some scholars to conclude that the original letter to the Romans consisted of only [1:1–15:33](#), but few now follow this theory. The best early manuscripts place the doxology at the end of ch [16](#), and the whole of ch [16](#) was most likely part of Paul's original letter to the Romans. See also study note on 16:1–16.

Romans 16:1

A deacon (Greek diakonos, "servant") refers both to a Christian who is recognized as a servant of Christ and specifically to someone who holds the office of deacon in a particular church (see [Phil 1:1](#); [1 Tim 3:8–12](#); cp. [Acts 6:1–6](#)). • Cenchrea was located about five miles from Corinth and functioned as its port. Paul might have been writing this letter to the Romans from Corinth on a winter-long stop there near the end of his third missionary journey (see [Acts 20:2–3](#)).

Romans 16:1–16

Paul here commended and greeted twenty-seven Roman Christians, ten of whom were women. Women played important roles in the early church. • Paul had never been to Rome, which has led to some speculation as to how he knew so many people there. One theory is that ch [16](#) was actually part of another letter that Paul sent to Ephesus. However, we have no good manuscript evidence for a separate letter (cp. study note on 15:33). Perhaps the answer is that Paul was able to greet so many people in Rome because he had encountered them during their travels away from Rome (see Romans Book Introduction, "Setting").

Romans 16:2

she has been helpful to many: This phrase indicates the ancient role of the patron, a wealthy person who used influence and money to help people and causes. Phoebe was apparently a woman of wealth and influence who used her resources to help missionaries such as Paul.

Romans 16:3

Priscilla and Aquila were Paul's good friends. After leaving Rome around AD 49, they became his co-workers for an extended time in Corinth and Ephesus (see [Acts 18–19](#)). They had apparently returned to Rome by the time Paul wrote Romans (about AD 57).

Romans 16:3–16

Although Paul had never visited the Christian community in Rome, he established rapport with these believers by personally greeting many of the church's members. The names reveal that the Roman Christian community was very diverse—Jews and Gentiles, slaves and free, men and women all formed a new society in the church (see [Gal 3:26–29](#)).

Romans 16:5

the church that meets in their home: Early Christians did not have large buildings for their meetings—they met in private homes. The church in Rome was composed of a number of house churches where small groups of believers gathered for worship and instruction.

Romans 16:7

In Greek, the name Junia could refer to a man named *Junias* or to a woman named *Junia*. Most interpreters understand *Junia* as a feminine name. This section pairs masculine and feminine names to refer to husband-and-wife teams, so Junia was probably a woman. • who were in prison with me: When this occurred is uncertain. According to Acts, Paul had been imprisoned overnight in Philippi ([Acts 16:19–28](#)); after Romans was written, he would later be imprisoned for two years in Caesarea ([Acts 24:27](#)) and for two years in Rome ([Acts 28:30–31](#)). Paul was undoubtedly imprisoned on occasions not mentioned in Acts (see [2 Cor 11:23](#)). • highly respected among the apostles: This phrase probably indicates that Andronicus and Junia were apostles—i.e., accredited missionaries of the church (see [Acts 14:4, 14](#); [1 Cor 9:5–6](#); [Gal 2:9](#)).

Romans 16:10

This Aristobulus was probably the same man as the brother of Herod Agrippa I; Aristobulus was a member of the Roman aristocracy who lived in Rome many years prior to his death in AD 48 or 49 (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.8.4; *War* 2.11.6). His household probably refers to his family and their servants in Rome.

Romans 16:13

This Rufus might be the individual mentioned as the son of Simon of Cyrene, who carried Christ's cross (see [Mark 15:21](#)).

Romans 16:16

with a sacred kiss: The kiss was a common way to greet another person in the ancient world and

particularly among the Jews. It is mentioned frequently in the New Testament as a greeting ([1 Cor 16:20](#); [2 Cor 13:12](#); [1 Thes 5:26](#); see [1 Pet 5:14](#)); the kiss of peace became a standard feature of the Christian liturgy by the second century.

Romans 16:17

people who cause divisions: Paul had trouble with divisive false teachers elsewhere (see Galatians, Colossians, 1 Timothy), so he warned the Roman church about this danger.

Romans 16:20

The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet: Paul alludes to the curse that God pronounced upon the serpent after he had deceived Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden ([Gen 3:15](#)). Christ, the offspring of Eve, will soon crush Satan under the feet of the church (cp. [Matt 16:18–19](#)).

Romans 16:21

Timothy was one of Paul's closest ministry associates. Timothy accompanied Paul on his second missionary journey ([Acts 16:2–3](#)) and was with Paul in Corinth while Paul wrote this letter to the Roman church (see [Acts 20:2–4](#)).

Romans 16:22

Tertius was the scribe (or *amanuensis*) who wrote the letter as Paul dictated. Most ancient letter writers employed such a scribe.

Romans 16:23

This Erastus was probably the individual Paul sent from Ephesus to Macedonia during his third missionary journey ([Acts 19:21–22](#); see [2 Tim 4:20](#)). An inscription in Corinth mentions an Erastus who was a city magistrate, possibly the same Erastus mentioned here.

Romans 16:25

plan (literally *mystery*): For Paul, the *mystery* is the truth about God and his plan that was not clearly known in the Old Testament era but which has been revealed in the New Testament era. While the Old Testament predicted the conversion of Gentiles, it did not make clear that Gentiles would become equal members of the people of God without becoming proselytes of Judaism.

Romans 16:25–27

This doxology makes a very appropriate conclusion to Paul's letter and its argument, reprising many of the themes found at the very beginning ([1:1–15](#)). • The doxology is missing in two late manuscripts and is in different places in other manuscripts (after [14:23](#) and after [15:33](#)). Therefore, these verses might have been added to Paul's letter at a later time. However, the majority of manuscripts do include the doxology at the end of the letter, and it uses vocabulary and themes common in the rest of the letter. Paul most likely wrote it himself as a conclusion to the letter.

Romans 16:26

so that they too might believe and obey him: Paul uses the same language about the mission to the Gentiles that he used in [1:5](#), creating a beautiful frame around the letter as a whole.